Auf Wiedersehen Walter

Walter Ulbricht's anger had descended into senility by the time the curtain fell on his life on 1 August 1973, just a month before the GDR was admitted to the UN. Possibly out of guilt – and certainly on the orders of Brezhnev – his passing roused Honecker to one of his most notable displays of magnanimity. He instructed Neues Deutschland – still the most deafening SED organ – to run a black-bordered front page with an obituary documenting Ulbricht's contribution to the GDR's founding, painting him as an ornament of an 'old world', who deserved respect for his past services. Predictably, the obituary notice carefully avoided mentioning his policies in the 50s and 60s.

Over in the West, Ulbricht's demise was greeted with a bored yawn. 'Personally, he was cruel, unappealing, and uninspiring,' The Times asserted when describing an efficient functionary who wielded immense power in an anonymous manner. His goatee beard and high-pitched voice, the paper added, 'inspired ridicule', and even in his personal relations his 'contempt for all human considerations' was evident'.1 America ignored his passing. In fact, a State Department cable, instructed ambassadors that, 'since the United States does not have diplomatic relations with the GDR, you should not sign the Ulbricht book'.2 In a lavish funeral, the former First Secretary was buried alongside the urns of Otto Grotewohl, Wilhelm Pieck and Rosa Luxemburg at the Friedrichsfelde Central Cemetery, (and a stone's throw from Honecker's fiery ex-wife, Edith Baumann, who had been interred nearby after succumbing to cancer a few months earlier). Remarkably, though Brezhnev didn't attend, the Soviet Union's main national television network ran a direct relay from the funeral. In a final gesture of 'goodwill', Honecker permitted the Institute of Marxism-Leninism at the SED Central Committee to publish 'selected works of Comrade Walter Ulbricht'.

Throughout this period, Erich Honecker's gaze had been fixed on the Middle East where tensions between Israel and her neighbours had reached